Roggeveen and Bouman: An Inventory of all the Narratives

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Motto: *En al klinkt het soms wat raar, Wat gedrukt staat dar is waar.*
[And though it may sound odd, What has been printed is the truth].
Jacob Cats, 17th Century Dutch National poet, famous for his moralistic rhymes

Introduction

It has become clear to me from the discussions at the Rapa Nui Rendezvous in Laramie, Wyoming in August, as well as from the article printed in the September issue of *RNJ*, that a most lamentable confusion still exists concerning the narratives of the discovery of Easter Island in April 1722. Only the language barrier permits this ambiguity to continue. With this in mind, I have decided to make an inventory of all the narratives on this voyage, tell something of their history, and give evaluations by others and comments by myself.

Before we can start with the inventory I must first repeat a bit of history. In my first article on Roggeveen's journey in *RNJ* 4(3):35, 45, I explained that Roggeveen was practically arrested upon his arrival in Batavia in July 1722, that the ships under his command and his journal were confiscated and he was sent back to Holland as a prisoner. This was done by the V.O.C. (the Dutch United East India Company) because Roggeveen had allegedly violated their charter by entering waters West of the island of New Guinea.

Of Roggeveen's confiscated Journal, two copies were made by the V.O.C. in Batavia. The original was sent to the Amsterdam Chamber of the V.O.C. and one copy was kept in the archive in Batavia. Neither of these documents have ever been seen again. The other copy was sent to the Zeeland Chamber of the V.O.C. in Roggeveen's hometown of Middleburg, where it disappeared. I shall return to this later.

Inventory and History

Following in sequence, an inventory can be made of the narratives:

1) The first to be printed was an anonymous publication called *Kort en Nauwkeurig Verhall van de Reize door 3 Schepen in 't Jaar 1721 gedaan,* printed in two different editions in Amsterdam in 1727. The full title takes almost an entire page; it is usually abbreviated to *Kort en Nauwkeurig Verhall* (Short and Accurate Narrative). Short it certainly is; it is more a pamphlet than a book, containing only 15 pages--two of them on Easter Island.

The story begins by telling that the author, hidden behind the initials T.d.H., met a sailor in Amsterdam who told him the "true' story about Roggeveen's journey in his own words" and that he "related from a small letter from his pocket on which he had made notes from time to time." It is clear already that this is no journal, and its unreliability is evident. On page 7, it says that Easter Island was discovered on April 6th (the correct date was April 5th), a mistake endlessly repeated later. In this first publication the story of the "giants" already comes up: that Rapanui men were twelve feet high, the women "only" ten feet, etc. The short text is interspersed with moralistic little poems about the hardships on this unsuccessful trip; I find them rather endearing:

"*.....You bring nothing back, but must be content*
With an empty purse, that's why I say:
Farewell Southland, farewell, you cannot charm me,
I do not seek those treasures, that mislead so many"

and then the poet asks from whom he can borrow wings to fly to heaven and rest there in peace. This is perhaps the most authentic part of the entire pamphlet.

2) The second anonymous publication appeared in 1728, its title: *Tweejaarige Reyze door de Straat Magellanes en rondom de Wereld ter nader Ontdekkinge der onbekende Zuydlanden,* Dordrecht, 1728. The title already contains a blatant mistake because Roggeveen did not sail through the Straits of Magellan but rounded Cape Horn. There were also later editions of this book in 1758, 1764 and 1774, so obviously it was in demand.

The introduction of this "Two Years' Journey" is a bit on the same line as the earlier pamphlet; the edi-

tor (1728:3) states: "The narratives that follow were handed over to me and prepared by me for printing; I have elaborated when indicated with short historical descriptions of the countries, regions and peoples visited, as collected by the most trustworthy authors on these regions. And because extraordinary matters hardly find belief in this century, amongst which the stories about the giants, as seen by my travelers, and might therefore lightly be discarded as trivial nonsense, it will become clear to you from the descriptions by men whose judgment has always been respected that in those countries people of such an exceptional length have been found in more than one region."

The difficulty with this book is that one never knows when the narrating sailor is giving his own impressions or the editor is interrupting with his "descriptions" that demonstrate his erudition because they show that he has indeed read many books on these subjects.

The narrator (ibid.:41,44) says that he has always had an insatiable appetite for traveling and that the coming departure of Roggeveen's fleet gave him a unique opportunity to satisfy his desire. So he joined the West Indies Company as a sailor. He states: "On the 6th day of this month (the same mistake!) we discovered an island hitherto unknown." "As soon as we had anchored..." (compare with Behrens who wrote, "We could not anchor that day"), "we sighted a nice little sloop of a very strange shape, completely sewn together from pieces of wood, hardly more than half a foot long. This sloop was manned by one man alone, a giant of 12 feet long who tried in vain to escape...." Then he repeats word for word the text from the *Short and Accurate Narrative* on how the sailors could pass between the legs of the giants without bowing their heads. This is certainly plagiarized from the earlier publication.

The sailor (ibid.:44,51-2) gives some interesting eye-witness accounts: "these men had their bodies painted with a red or dark brown color and the women with a scarlet color" and a description of a banana is given: it is characterized as a "fig" and its leaves were used to protect man from the sun and rain and that Adam and Ever had already used such "fig leaves" for cover. As for the statues, he notes "Two stones of a size that surpasses belief serve them as gods. One stone was exceedingly large and lay on the earth, on top of this one there was another stone of such size and height that seven of our men with outstretched arms could hardly embrace it." And, "It seemed impossible to us that these stones could have been moved, however strong the inhabitants were, and placed on top of the other." The names of the gods were "Taurico" and "Dago" (also mentioned in the *Short and Accurate Narrative*). "For these idols the savages had deep respect and they venerated them with great esteem, principally by dancing, jumping, jubilation and the clapping of hands in the way, as we read it in the Bible, that the children of Israel honored the Golden Calf (ibid.:54).

It is rewarding to follow the editor (ibid.:44), when he takes over again from the sailor's narrative for, evidently realizing that he is stretching things a bit in regard to the giants, he adds: "I do not doubt that most people that read about this voyage will not believe me and will consider this story about the giants an invention...but I will prove this in the next chapter."

The following chapter cites the Bible as proof, mentioning Og, the King of Bazan, Goliath and the children of Enak (in whose eyes the Israelites were like locusts). Then comes stories of giants in other regions, mainly Patagonia: "I would not be surprised if someone...might think that these giants might possibly be descendants of the Kanaanites, who venerated amongst their gods an idol named Dagon. Their bodies were outsized, but they were driven out of the country by Joshua. But it is more probable that these [giants] belong to the family of the Patagonians...who were driven by a storm in their tiny sloops from the mainland to this island." [Well, here we have from one of the very first visitors Heyerdahl's thesis presented more than 200 years 'avant la lettre']. "But if these Patagonians are not themselves descendants of those old Kanaanites and inhabitants of Phoenicia, who, flying from Joshua from the Mediterranean and driven by a storm across the great ocean to the beaches of South America and from there to the nearest (sic) islands, I do not believe that anyone will reject that off hand or accept it as the full truth." (ibid.:54).

An illustration from the *Two Years' Voyage* has

been reproduced in *Easter Island Studies*, edited by S.R. Fischer (1993:73); it is indeed the earliest illustration ever published about Easter Island.

While on the subject of giants--without wishing anyone to believe these stories--I must draw attention to the journal of Captain Felipe Gonzalez who visited Easter Island in 1770. He states (Corney 1908:99) that the men were very tall: "...there were two whom out of curiosity we measured, one of 6 feet 5 inches and the other 6 feet and 6½ inches, all their limbs being of proportionate measures." One cannot deny that at least these two Rapanui men were exceptionally tall even by today's standards.

3) *Nader Onderzoek en Bericht van zijne Reyse naar de Zuid-Landen* by C.F. Behrens was first published in Amsterdam in 1732; later German editions appeared in 1737 and 1739 and a French edition also in 1739 (Sharp 1970:17). Behrens at least had had a better education than the two anonymous sailors but he was too much like Baron van Münchhausen: exaggerating his own role in all events. He was an adventurer, born in 1701 in the Duchy of Mecklenburg (Germany), and came to the Netherlands to try his luck. He joined the West Indies Company's fleet as a member of the small military group that Roggeveen had on board to conquer Southland. Behrens claims that he was the "commander" of this group and the first to set foot on Easter Island. Het Zeeuwsch Genootschap der Wetenschappen (The Scientific Society of Zealand) checked Behrens' claims; it appears he joined the fleet as a soldier and was later promoted to corporal. However, a sergeant and a lieutenant were above him in rank (Annual Report, Middelburg 1911:50). Behrens had no knowledge of navigation whatsoever.

Behrens' German edition was translated into English by Corney (1908) and added as Appendix I to the 1903 (pp.131-7) edition of the Hakluyt Society on the *Voyage of Don Felipe Gonzalez to Easter Island in 1770-1771*. I studied the French edition of 1739 and found there are marked differences between the two (my page numbers refer to the French edition). Some of Behrens' (1793:121-3) remarks compare to points already mentioned from the other books: "The island was discovered on the 6th of April;" and on the subject of a naked fisherman coming on board, he states that "...his body was completely painted with all sorts of figures." As for size, he notes that "He was rather tall, strong and robust." That is not exactly a giant. Behrens also observes that islanders had tattoos in the form of birds, a point not noted by others. He remarks that "They made fires at the foot of their statues and made offerings and prayers there to their idols." More quotations will follow in another context.

4) One of the first English translations of the anonymous accounts was by John Hamilton Moore, in *A New and Complete Collection of Voyages and Travels*, London, 1778 [see article in RNJ, Vol.7 (3)].

This then is the material by which Roggeveen's journey had to be judged between the years 1727 and 1838. No wonder that no one could figure out exactly what had happened on that trip. After publication of the reports on the Pacific voyages of La Perouse and Captain Cook, students began to compare them to find out the exact geographical location of the islands that had been discovered and to compare their names. This was not easy; Roggeveen had a habit of baptizing islands by trivial names that related to incidents during his visits. The name Easter Island itself is an example, but he also created Dirty Island, Harmful Island (where they lost the *Afrikaansche Galey*), Traitors Island, Flies Island, Refreshment Island, Dawn and Dusk, etc. Sailors from other nations had given more exalted names to the same islands (they seldom inquired as to what the natives called them). The question was to find out which island was which.

In 1798 a French scholar made an effort in this direction: C.P. Claret Fleurieu wrote *Voyage autour du Monde pendant les Annees 1790, 1791, et 1792 par Etienne Marchand...auquel on a joint un Examen Critique du Voyage de Roggeween*, Paris 1798-1800. This consists of four tremendous and beautiful tomes with valuable maps included. But it is no wonder that Fleurieu was frustrated by the contradictions in the narratives which were available at that time. His 'critical examination' becomes prejudiced against Roggeveen. He writes (Fleurieu 1798:275) about: "...the obscurity, up the present impenetrable, that reigns in the relations of the voyage of this admiral" and, further on, "There is no one who presents to the geographer less exact determinations and less proper bases to serve as a foundation for his work." His conclusion: "The Dutch narratives inspire little confidence." Quite so: Roggeveen has

not spoken yet.

Some of Fleurieu's statements require comment: he takes note of the "giants" in the Dutch narratives (ibid.:278) and states, "The giants mentioned... could well be these colossal statues found all over the island." That remark shows some logic, only the anonymous naratives clearly relate to living persons. Fleurieu adds to the confusion himself in his efforts at geography. Zero meridian over the Greenwich Observatory in England had not yet been universally accepted, thus the French worked with zero meridian over Paris and the Dutch with the Teide, the snow capped volcano on Tenerife in the Canary Islands. Fleurieu can't figure out all these different meridians, particularly because Behrens indicates a different location. Then he comes up with a brilliant solution: Behrens, being German, must have worked with zero meridian from his "native city of Mecklenburg" (ibid.:286). In fact, there has never been a city of Mecklenburg; Behrens was born in Rostock, in the Duchy of Mecklenberg. Sharp (1970:16) repeats this mistake.

Fleurieu (1798-1800:287) also gives Roggeveen bad marks because the anonymous narratives indicate the day of the discovery of Easter Island as the 6th of April and, in looking at the calendar, he has found that Easter Day in 1722 was on the 5th. He considers this an inaccuracy on the part of Roggeveen.

Fleurieu mentions another book on Roggeveen's voyage by John Harris, published in 1764 (first edition probably published in 1745) in which the editor states that this narrative was supplied by the officer who commanded the troops on the Admiral's ship, but whose name is not mentioned. Behrens served on the Admiral's ship and I suspect him to have supplied the manuscript for translation into English. Fleurieu does not mention the title, but its date of publication is prior to that of John Hamilton Moore.

All this shows the harm done to the reputation of Jacob Roggeveen by the absence of his own journal, which made any serious study of his voyage virtually impossible. People in the Dutch province of Zealand were upset by the harsh criticisms made by Fleurieu and tried to rehabilitate Roggeveen's reputation by writing a pamphlet with this in mind. However, they had little to go on.

Historians knew that a copy of Roggeveen's own journal had been sent to Middelburg on 30 November 1722 because a letter existed that advised of the arrival of that document. A search was begun and then, in 1836 (114 years later!), someone opened a file concerning Surinam and out came Roggeveen's journal. It had been misfiled. More details can be found about all this in Andrew Sharp (1970).

5. In 1838, the Zeeuwsch Genootschap der Wetenschappen published *Dagverhaal der Ontdekkingsreis van Mr. Jacob Roggeveen in de Jaren 1721 en 1722*, Middelburg. This was Roggeveen's own journal, the only authentic source. From that moment on, one had no longer to rely on the apocryphal fantasies published before. But for many years no one outside the Netherlands paid attention to this most important publication.

This is the moment to revert to the day of the discovery of Easter Island. The anonymous accounts as well as Behrens mention 6 April; Roggeveen himself offers the solution. He writes in his journal that in the evening of the 5th, the *Afrikaansche Galey* (the smallest and fastest ship, always sailing ahead and used for reconnaissance) "...headed into the wind in order to wait for us, giving a signal of seeing land...we asked what she had seen, whereupon it was answered that they had seen very distinctly ahead to starboard a low flat island...." "Here upon it was found fitting...to let drift so as to wait for the coming of the day. This being thus decided, we gave to Captain Bouman, who was astern, the relevant information and to the land the name of Paasch Eiland because it was discovered and found by us on Easter Day." Roggeveen's question, "We asked what she had seen..." makes it absolutely clear that only the *Afrikaansche Galey* was near enough to the coast for its crew to see the island; those on the other ships, including Roggeveen himself, only saw the island the following day, the 6th. This entry also makes it clear that Roggeveen baptized the island before dusk on the 5th, even before he had seen it himself. Fischer, in *Easter Island Studies* (1993:63) quotes both me and Behrens, saying that the naming took place upon departure, the 10th of April. The quotes are correct, but Roggeveen's entry in his journal of April 5th proves that both Bouman and Behrens were wrong. It is possible they only heard of the name on the 10th. The first English translation of the sec-

tion in Roggeveen's own journal that concerns Easter Island was published in Corney, 1908.

6. In February 1910 when F.E. Baron Mulert started to edit Roggeveen's journal for publication in the series, Linschoten Vereeniging, he missed the journal of Captain Cornelis Bouman of the *Tienhoven,* the second ship in Roggeveen's fleet. The board of the Linschoten Vereeniging sent a circular to its members to look for it and, before the month was out, a copy appeared, found among some family papers. It was again the Zeeuwsch Genootschap der Wetenschappen that was the first to publish it in its annual report on the year 1911: *Scheepsjournaal gehouden op het schip Tienhoven tijdens de Ontdekkingsreis van Mr. Jacob Roggeveen, 1721-1722,* edited by F.E. Baron Mulert. In his introduction, Mulert (1911:58) expresses the opinion that in seamanship, Bouman even surpassed Roggeveen; the exactitude of his indications and his nautical details were considered of the greatest importance. This is without doubt the second most important journal. It was only at the Laramie Rendezvous that I realized that, as far as I know, I was the first to come up with a translation in English of some of the details (RNJ 4:4). A complete translation is surely needed here.

7. In the 1811 edition of the Linschoten Vereeniging edited by Baron Mulert, *De Reis van Mr. Jacob Roggeveen,* the full text of both journals of Roggeveen and Bouman were published with many notes and comments added. (Only the daily meteorological reports were omitted). This edition must be considered as the standard work on this voyage.

8. In 1970 an excellent translation in English by Andrew Sharp, *The Journal of Jacob Roggeveen* was published by Clarendon Press, Oxford. This not only contains Roggeveen's own journal, but includes notes whenever Bouman or Behrens have something significant to add.

So much for the inventory.

EVALUATION

It was only after its first publication in 1838 that investigators began comparing Roggeveen's own journal with the stories that had been published a century earlier. Those who did, came to the following conclusions:

1. The first to comment on the old sources after the discovery of Roggeveen's journal was the Zeeuwsch Genootschap der Wetenschappen in their 1838 publication of *Dagverhaal*: "It is clear how little one can trust the stories of those two authors." They then give fifteen pages of corrections on the route taken; the geographical position of Easter Island; the 'big battle' in the North Sea against five pirate ships (as described by Behrens--Roggeveen only mentions seeing five ships in the distance); and the incorrect map included in the booklet, etc.

2. Prof. Dr. C.E. Meinicke from Dresden was the first investigator outside the Netherlands to take note of Roggeveen's journal; he made a detailed study of Roggeveen's navigation, observing that the anonymous narratives are no journals at all, but all from memory after the sailors had returned: "...both writers are...equally unreliable and untrustworthy. In short, it is beyond doubt that nothing can be done with these sources." (Meinicke 1874:4-5).

3. Bolton Glanvill Corney (1908:XXII) writes in his introduction to the Hakluyt Society edition, *Tweejarige Reyze*: "The writer, whose identity has never been revealed but who appears to have been one of the persons embarked in the expedition, brought notoriety--if not ridicule--upon himself, and some discredit upon the whole undertaking, by the fanciful and palpable fictions with which he interspersed his father illiterate narration."

4. In 1908 the journal of Captain Bouman of the *Tienhoven* was found and published. It fully corroborates Roggeveen's own journal.

5. The Linschoten Vereniging published in 1911 the texts of both Roggeveen and Bouman for comparison, with corrections and notes; it is edited by Mulert.

6. To my knowledge, the most recent comparison between Roggeveen's journal and the old accounts is by Sharp (1970). He (ibid.:14-15) notes, "Before 1836 the main sources of knowledge of Roggeveen's voyage had been published accounts of a markedly corrupt and misleading character."

In short, all investigators that I have been able to find dissociated themselves from the old sources after comparing them to Roggeveen's and Bouman's journals. For those who might not find this convincing enough, I give a few textual comparisons on two subjects, the landscape and female behavior on Easter Island in 1722:

"These stone statues caused us great surprise: because we could not understand how it was possible these people, who are devoid of heavy and thick wood, to make any machine...could erect these statues of more than ten feet high" (Roggeveen, 10 April; quoted from Mulert 1911:121).

However, Behrens (1739:138) states that "The whole [island] is cultivated and well kept, it is full of woods and forests."

In regard to women, Roggeveen (Mulert 1911:123) states "It is also very remarkable that we saw no more than 2 or 3 old women, that wore a dress from the waist down to the knees, and another cloth draped over the shoulder but in such a way that the drooping skins of their breasts were exposed. But young women and daughters did not appear so that one has to believe that jealousy must have induced the men to hide these women in a remote part of the island." In contrast, Behrens (1739:133-4) notes "The islanders showed their women to the landed sailors and made it clear that they were 'available' to the sailors. The women sat themselves amidst the sailors, and undressed smiling as if they were tempting them with different gestures. Others, who had remained in their houses, called and gestured them to come in."

I think that this comparison makes the problem sufficiently clear; what is one to believe and what not? The reader must make that decision himself. This does not mean that all the old accounts are lies, but with such unreliable sources one has to be extremely careful.

If we now, with all this information at hand, look again at the article presented in the previous issue of *RNJ* (Vol.7,No.3:54-6), we see that John Hamilton Moore's 1778 account came from the earlier Dutch publications; we cannot blame Moore for his inaccuracies, published fifty years before Roggeveen's journal saw the light of day. However, in *RNJ*, Moore's book is introduced as providing new details concerning Easter Island archaeology and ethnology--"of great interest for all experts...."

How a rehash of the old fantasies can be considered as a contribution to the history of Easter Island is difficult to understand and impossible to justify.

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